first robbed the zamindars of their right to sell or mortgage their land in Punjab's first piece of colonial paternal land legislation. By 1906, it should have been clear to the rulers that 'the colonists hated the extra-legal fine system that had cost them over Rs. 3,00,000 in penalties'. As if this was not enough, the severely oppressed and downtrodden peasant grantees had salt rubbed into their wounds as they came to feel that 'more offensive than fines, however, was the rampant corruption amongst lower officials' who made the greatest possible use of extorting bribes. [7]

In this way, the conditions for an agrarian revolt were ripe. At a livestock show in Lyallpur on 22 and 23 March 1907, approximately 9,000 colonists converged. Their aim was to protest against government despotism. A local editor, Lala Bankay Dyal, [8] opened the programme. He began an inflammatory poem titled '*Pagri Sambhal O Jatta*' ('Protect the honour of your turban, o Jatta!'). The scene was memorably depicted in Manoj Kumar's 1965 film *Shaheed*, [9] the first film that went onto win the Indian government's 'Best Feature Film on National Unity and Emotional Integration Award' [10] in Hindi, and the poem is part of Indian folklore. Lala Bankay Dyal's recital in real life, however, was far more explosive because, 'the Turban was a symbol of self-respect for the war-like Jat Zamindars . . .'. [11] After a number of patriotic songs had been sung, it was Lala Lajpat Rai and Ajit Singh who made the main speeches, but Ajit Singh was by far the fiercest in his criticism. James Ker was not far wrong when he recalled that whilst Lajpat Rai 'was the most prominent of the "intellectuals" associated with the movement' so that 'he was everywhere recognised as the moving spirit of the agitation', when it came to Ajit Singh, 'he was much more prominent as a speaker than Lajpatrai, and his speeches were much more violent . . .'. [12] The crowd was whipped up into a frenzy. Whereas Lala Lajpat Rai was more conciliatory, Ajit Singh 'spoke of the need for bloody sacrifice and demanded a boycott of all government posts'. Colonists, he said, should band together and not pay revenue. After the March meeting, Lala Lajpat Rai went on a lecture tour of the United Provinces, but Ajit Singh and his organization, the *Anjuman-hi-Mohibann-i-Watan* (Society of Lovers of the Homeland) orchestrated demonstrations against the Bari Doab